

a mega-order for 470 narrow- and widebody jets earlier this year. And as the country transforms into the world's third-largest economy by the end of 2030, Air India is positioning itself as a leading global carrier embodying the aspiration of a New India. In pursuit of this objective, the iconic brand that returned to the Tata group on January 27, 2022, has rolled out a five-year-long Vihaan.AI turnaround programme. "Our mission and job at the Tata group and Air India are to make this a truly iconic airline that every Indian is truly proud of," Chandrasekaran had said at a gathering of Air India employees,

possibilities' comes in."

The carrier also plans to use the livery as a metaphor for the disruption that it seeks to introduce in the world's fastest-growing aviation market. Chandrasekaran broadly hinted at it when he promised to introduce cutting-edge technologies at the airline over the next 12 months. "We will have the best of machine learning and the best of artificial intelligence deployed in Air India than in any other airline." After all, the \$150-billion salt-to-software conglomerate also houses TCS, the country's largest IT services company.

The deliveries of the first of the

national city on its route network. A completely overhauled website and mobile app built from the ground up and offering a vastly improved experience with new and improved digital tools has been launched. A new customer contact centre offering 24x7 service in nine Indian and foreign languages will be in place by 2023-end. And by early 2024, a new frequent flyer programme interfacing with the multipurpose Tata Neu super app would be launched.

Also, what has come as a huge relief to many is the airline's decision to retain the company's Maharaja mascot. Calling the rumours of it being phased out highly exaggerated,

NEW AIR INDIA FOR A NEW INDIA

- 1 Immediate upgrades are business lounges on international routes, an overhauled website and a mobile app
- 2 The carrier has retained the Maharaja mascot, conceptualised by the airline's legendary Commercial Director Bobby Kooka
- 3 The iconic Indian window shape is reimagined as a gold window frame or Vista to symbolise a portal into a 'Window of Possibilities'
- 4 A 24x7 customer contact centre in nine Indian and foreign languages to be in place by 2023-end; a new frequent flier programme to be launched by 2024

vendors and other stakeholders on August 10 in New Delhi.

What stands out in the entire exercise is the new 'Vista' logo, a peak golden frame, signifying a portal to send the airline into the realm of limitless possibilities. "The biggest challenge and opportunity were about taking forward the brand's legacy," Prasoon Joshi, CEO of McCann World Group India, which has the advertising and marketing communications mandate for the carrier, tells *Business Today*. "And when you are doing that as part of a larger evolution, you also need to free yourself. And that's where the idea of the Vista or 'the window of

aircraft, Airbus 350, donning the new look are expected to start towards the end of the year. "In just a few months, the Airbus 350, Airbus' most modern aircraft, will arrive in India to join Air India's fleet. Then in a year, the first of our 43 widebody aircraft will enter the hangar for a complete interior refit, including new seats and in-flight entertainment at the cost of \$400 million. It is the largest refit ever undertaken by an Indian airline," informed CEO Campbell Wilson.

Besides, the airline is rolling out several other upgrades for passengers. For starters, there is now a business lounge serving each new inter-

Wilson said, "The Maharaja will live on and continue to be part of the airline's journey into the future."

In the same breath, the management also admits that considerable ground remains to be covered both in terms of upgrading the staff and fleet. Jitender Bhargava, the carrier's former executive director, calls the initial reactions to the rebrand temporary. "The exercise has made the brand a talking point by raising its profile though people can either like or dislike it. Over time, Air India will be patronised for the quality of products it offers." **BT**

@manishpant22